

Real-World Ethical Cases

Social media algorithms — four documented incidents of algorithmic harm

Facebook 2021

Political Division

Leaked internal documents showed the algorithm amplified anger-inducing posts because they got more reactions — actively increasing political polarisation among users.

SOURCE Horwitz, Seetharaman & Wells — "The Facebook Files", Wall Street Journal, 2021

TikTok 2020

Demographic Bias

The For You Page suppressed content from creators based on race, appearance, or political views — giving certain groups systematically less algorithmic reach regardless of content quality.

SOURCE Bandy & Diakopoulos — "Curating Quality? Auditing the Algorithmic Power of Platforms", 2021

YouTube 2019

Rabbit Hole Effect

To maximise watch time, the algorithm gradually steered users from mainstream content toward increasingly extreme videos — a documented pathway toward radicalisation.

SOURCE Ribeiro et al. — "Auditing Radicalization Pathways on YouTube", ACM FAccT Conference, 2019

Twitter / X 2021

Political Amplification

Twitter's own internal audit found right-leaning political content was amplified more than left-leaning content across multiple countries — with no clear explanation even from the platform itself.

SOURCE Twitter Engineering Team — "Algorithmic Amplification of Politics on Twitter", Official Report, 2021